8-WEEK PLAN

The Conjugate Method

8 weeks, 4 days.

Days 4 a week **Session** 50–60 min **Equipment** Commercial gym
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What this is

Muscle grows from two different signals. The first is heavy tension: a set under a load that only allows a handful of reps, taken close to the point where the next rep will not move. The second is metabolic stress: the pump, a muscle kept full of blood under short rest until it burns. Most programs make you choose one. This plan runs both in the same session, on the same muscle. One anchor set, two bridge sets at two reps in reserve, then a seven-set finisher with the clock running. The anchor set comes from the heavy-duty tradition and the seven-set finisher from the pump tradition of pro bodybuilding. Running both in one session, with a bridge between them, is the part that's mine. This is the four-day version, built for the schedule most people actually have. Most people want the same thing from a gym: less fat and more muscle. The lifting builds and keeps the muscle. The food takes the fat. The split is upper, lower, upper, lower. Every muscle trains twice a week, three to four days apart, and each session gives one priority muscle the full treatment. The plan runs at two levels, so the same eight weeks fit someone in their second year of training and someone in their tenth. The eight weeks are two four-week blocks: three weeks climbing a rep ladder at one load, one lighter week, then the same again heavier. Week 8 ends with a re-test against week 1, so you leave with a number, not a feeling.

Who it's for

- One year or more of consistent training. Level 1 under two years, Level 2 after.
- Four days a week available, 50 to 60 minutes a session.
- A commercial gym with the usual machines and a cable station.
- Training at maintenance or in a moderate deficit. In a hard cut, run Level 1.

Who it's not for

- Anyone under a year of training. The first year grows on almost any plan, and the time is better spent learning the movements on a simpler one.
- Anyone training for an event on a date: a meet, a race, a season. This plan builds muscle and nothing else.
- Anyone who cannot get four sessions in most weeks. Two muscles would go a full week between hard days.

Equipment: a commercial gym. A Smith machine, dumbbells, adjustable benches, a machine shoulder press, a chest-supported row, an incline machine press, a cable station with a rope and single handles, a pulldown, a hack squat or machine squat, a leg press, leg extension, seated leg curl, a 45-degree hip extension bench, a hip thrust setup and a barbell. Every machine has a substitute in its session.

Before you start

Five rules.

1. The plan is decided before the week starts. You do not pick exercises in the gym. You open the table and do what it says.
2. Weekly averages, never single weigh-ins. Your weight swings two to five pounds a day from water and food. One number is noise. Use the seven-day average.
3. A missed day is data, not failure. It tells you what in the plan doesn't fit your life yet.
4. Log every session. The plan works off the record. Load, reps, and how many reps you had left, every set.
5. Progress is checked against the record, not how you feel. A session that felt bad and beat last week's numbers was a good session.

Your level

The plan runs at one of two levels. The sessions, the sets and the ladder are the same at both. Only the effort on two kinds of set changes.

	LEVEL 1	LEVEL 2
Who	One to two years of training. Coming back after time off. Joints that complain. A hard cut.	Two years or more of consistent training, at maintenance or in a moderate deficit.
Anchor set	Stop with one rep in reserve. No rest-pause.	To real failure, then rest-pause.
Finisher, set 7	One rep in reserve. No partials.	Past failure with partials or one drop in load.
Every other set	The same.	The same.

Failure is not required to grow. Sets that stop one to three reps short of failure build about as much muscle as sets taken all the way, when the number of sets is the same. What failure adds is a little more stimulus and a lot more fatigue. That trade only pays once you can tell where failure is. Most newer lifters stop several reps short and believe they hit it. Level 1 builds the skill. Level 2 spends it.

A hard cut means losing more than one percent of your bodyweight a week. Failure work on a deficit that large costs more recovery than you have. Run Level 1 until the rate slows.

Learning where failure is. At Level 1, once a week, take the last bridge set of one machine movement to real failure. Before the set, guess how many reps you will have left at the written number. Then count how many you actually get. The gap is how far off your reading is. When your guess lands within one rep three weeks in a row, you can read effort.

Moving up. Move to Level 2 at the start of a new eight weeks, never mid-block, once you have two years of consistent training and can read effort within one rep. A Level 2 lifter drops to Level 1 for a hard cut or a week of bad sleep, then goes back.

Finding your starting loads

There are no fixed weights anywhere in this document. Week 1, session 1 of each day is a load-finding session. The rule for each set type:

- Anchor set: climb through the ramp sets to a load where the bottom of the written range is the last clean rep at Level 2, or leaves one in reserve at Level 1. If you get two or more reps past the bottom of the range in week 1, go up next session.
- Bridge sets: a load you can lift for the bottom of the range with two left.
- Finisher: a load you can do for the bottom of the range on set 1 with two left. It will feel light. By set 5 it will not.
- Superset sets: the bottom of the range with two left. Light and strict.

Write every starting load down in session 1. Weeks 2 and 3 are built on those numbers.

The warm-up

Five minutes, the same every session.

1. Three minutes on a bike or rower at a pace you can talk through.
2. Ten arm circles each way, ten leg swings each side, ten squats, ten band pull-aparts.

3. Before every anchor set, ramp sets. They are not counted and not in the tables. The first anchor of the day gets three: about half the anchor load for 8 reps, about 70 percent for 5, then 85 to 90 percent for 2. Rest 60 seconds after the first, 90 seconds after the second, two minutes before the anchor. The reps drop as the load climbs, so the ramp warms the muscle without tiring it. The last ramp set is the check. If it moves slower than it should, today's anchor load comes down. An anchor later in the session, on a muscle that is already warm, gets two: 70 percent for 5, then 85 to 90 percent for 2. The ramp sets are how you find the anchor load, so do not skip them.

If something hurts in a way that isn't muscle fatigue, stop and see a professional. This plan is not medical advice.

The eight weeks

WEEK	WHAT CHANGES	LOAD RULE	NOTES
1	Load-finding week. Bottom of every rep ladder.	Find and log every starting load.	Anchor sets at your level from day 1. Log the rest-pause reps at Level 2.
2	One more rep per set.	Same load as week 1.	6 becomes 7. 10 becomes 11.
3	One more rep per set.	Same load. Top of the ladder.	Note every set that hit the top.
4	Deload.	Half the sets, 80 to 90 percent of the load.	Three to four in reserve. No sets to failure, no finishers.
5	New block. Bottom of the ladder.	Up 5 to 10 lb on big lifts, 2.5 to 5 lb on small ones, wherever week 3 hit the top.	Otherwise same load, ladder again.
6	One more rep per set.	Same load as week 5.	
7	One more rep per set.	Same load. Top of the ladder.	The heaviest week of the plan.
8	Deload and re-test.	Deload rules, plus the re-test below.	The number you walk away with.

The ladder

Weeks 1 to 3 are one block. The load does not change. The reps do. Every set is written as a ladder: 8→9→10 means eight reps in week 1, nine in week 2, ten in week 3, at the same weight. Anchor sets run 6→7→8 the same way, each week at your level's effort. The finisher runs its own ladder at one load across all seven sets.

Week 4 is the deload. Half the sets, 80 to 90 percent of the load, three to four reps in reserve on every set. The anchor set becomes one set at the bridge load, stopped with three or four left. The finisher comes out and is replaced by two easy sets of the same movement. The superset stays, lighter. The deload is not a week off. It is the week the growth from weeks 1 to 3 gets built.

Week 5 starts the second block. Every movement that hit the top of the ladder in week 3 at the written reps in reserve goes up: 5 to 10 lb on presses, rows, squats and deadlifts, 2.5 to 5 lb on curls, raises, extensions and flyes, back to the bottom of the ladder. Any movement that did not reach the top keeps its load and runs the ladder again. Weeks 6 and 7 add a rep each.

Week 8 is the second deload, with one addition. In the last session of each day type, do one set of every anchor movement at week 1's anchor load for week 1's reps, and stop there. You will not fail it. The point is to count what is left. In week 1 that load left you at failure or one in reserve at the bottom of the range. In week 8 it should leave two, three or more beyond that. Log the difference for each movement. No sets to failure in week 8 and no finishers.

Deload triggers

Any one of these fires a deload the same week, then you resume the block where you left it.

- Performance on a key lift drops two sessions in a row.
- Five days of feeling flat and heavy.
- A week of bad sleep.

Load-drop rules

If one muscle is going backwards while the rest of the body is fine, you do not need a full deload. Cut that muscle's sets by 30 to 40 percent for one week, superset sets first. The anchor set and the finisher on its priority day are the last things to touch. If two muscles are dropping at once, that is recovery, not programming. Deload.

The sessions

Every session has the same shape. The priority muscle goes first and gets the full treatment: anchor set, two bridge sets, finisher. Each muscle gets its anchor set on one day of the week and bridge sets on the other, so the hard work is spread across two sessions three or four days apart. The small muscles close the session as a superset. Tempo is four digits: seconds down, pause at the bottom, seconds up, pause at the top. 3-0-1-0 is three seconds down, no pause, one second up, no pause. On the anchor set the last reps slow down on their own. That is fine. Rest is written per row and it is timed, not felt.

The anchor set. The one heavy set for that muscle that day. At Level 2 it goes to real failure, then rest-pause. Real failure means the next rep would not move with good form, not the point where it gets uncomfortable. Rack the weight. Count fifteen to twenty seconds. Unrack and get two or three more reps. Rack it. That is the set. At Level 1 it stops with one rep left and there is no rest-pause. The anchor movement is always one you can rack in a second: a Smith machine, a machine, or a bar you can set down. Never heavy dumbbells. With heavy dumbbells the set ends on getting them into position, not on the muscle. Three minutes rest after it, and nothing done in that rest. The anchor set is where the tension signal comes from, and it needs the full three minutes.

The bridge sets. Work at two reps in reserve, strict, at both levels. The bridge adds mechanical work without spending the recovery the anchor set already spent. Never to failure. Two minutes rest on compounds, 90 seconds on isolations.

The finisher. Seven sets of one movement at one load, 30 to 45 seconds rest between sets, timed. Sets one to six stop at one or two reps in reserve. Set seven runs at your level. The rest is short enough that the muscle never empties. It stays full of blood the whole time, and that swelling is the second growth signal. Only the priority muscle gets one.

The superset. The small muscles close the session with two movements done back to back. One set of the first, straight into one set of the second, then 60 seconds rest. That is one round. The two movements work opposite muscles, so each one rests while the other works. Each movement loads its muscle in the stretched position, where the growth signal is strongest. Three rounds at two reps in reserve. Never to failure. Set both movements up on one cable tower where you can, so a round has no walking.

The clock. Sessions fit 50 to 60 minutes with the rests timed. If a session runs past 60 minutes, check the rests first. Untimed rest is where the minutes go. If it still runs long, drop one round of the superset, then cut the last bridge movement to one set. The priority muscle's anchor set, bridge sets and finisher are never cut for time.

Day 1: Upper A

Focus: chest. Back and side delts, bridge sets. Biceps and triceps superset to close.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Incline Smith press, anchor set	1	6→7→8	2-0-1-0	3:00	Three ramp sets. Bench at 30 degrees, bar to the upper chest. Level 2: to failure, then rest-pause: rack 15 to 20 seconds, two or three more reps. Level 1: stop with one in reserve.
Flat dumbbell press, bridge	2	8→9→10	3-0-1-0	2:00	Two in reserve.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Low-to-high cable fly, finisher	7	10→11→12	2-0-1-1	30–45 s	Same load all seven sets. Sets 1 to 6 one or two in reserve. Set 7 at your level.
Single-arm cable row, bridge	2	10→11→12 each side	2-0-1-1	90 s	Full stretch forward, elbow to the hip. Both sides, then rest.
Cable lateral raise, bridge	2	12→13→14 each side	2-0-1-1	90 s	Lean away from the stack so the cable loads the bottom. Lead with the elbow.
Behind-the-body cable curl, superset	3	10→11→12	2-0-1-1	none, straight into the next row	Face away from the stack, arm behind the body. Strict.
Overhead cable extension, superset	3	12→13→14	3-1-1-0	60 s after the round	Same tower. Full stretch behind the head, elbows in.

Substitutions: no Smith machine, use an incline machine press for the anchor. When the flat dumbbells get awkward to kick into place, use a machine chest press for the bridge. No low-to-high cable, use a pec deck with the handles set low or an incline dumbbell fly. No single-arm cable row, use a single-arm dumbbell row. No cable for laterals, use seated dumbbell lateral raises. No cable for the superset, use an incline dumbbell curl and a two-hand dumbbell overhead extension.

Day 2: Lower A

Focus: quads. Hamstrings, bridge sets. Abs superset to close.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Hack squat, anchor set	1	6→7→8	2-0-1-0	3:00	Three ramp sets. Feet mid-platform. Set the safety stops before the set. Level 2: failure plus rest-pause. Level 1: one in reserve.
Leg press, bridge	2	10→11→12	3-0-1-0	2:00	Two in reserve.
Leg extension, finisher	7	12→13→14	2-0-1-1	30–45 s	Seat reclined if the machine allows. Set 7 at your level.
Seated leg curl, bridge	2	10→11→12	2-0-1-1	90 s	Lean the torso forward to stretch the hamstrings. Two in reserve.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
45-degree hip extension, bridge	2	10→11→12	2-0-1-1	2:00	Round the upper back slightly and drive with the glutes and hamstrings, not the lower back. Hold a plate once bodyweight is easy.
Cable crunch, superset	3	15→16→17	2-0-1-1	none, straight into the next row	Pull with the abs, not the arms. Full range.
Hanging leg raise, superset	3	10→11→12	2-0-1-0	60 s after the round	No swing. Knees bent until straight legs are clean. Control the descent.

Substitutions: no hack squat, use a machine squat, a Smith squat, or a leg press with the feet low. No leg press, use a heavy goblet squat. No leg extension, use a sissy squat and accept a weaker finisher. No hip extension bench, use a cable pull-through. No cable crunch, use a weighted crunch holding a plate. No hanging bar, use lying leg raises.

Day 3: Upper B

Focus: back. Shoulders secondary. Chest, bridge sets. Side and rear delts superset to close.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Chest-supported row, anchor set	1	6→7→8	2-0-1-0	3:00	Three ramp sets. Chest stays on the pad. Level 2: failure plus rest-pause. Level 1: one in reserve.
Wide-grip pulldown, bridge	2	8→9→10	3-0-1-0	2:00	Width. Two in reserve.
Overhead cable pullover, finisher	7	12→13→14	2-1-1-1	30–45 s	Big stretch at the top, full lat contraction at the bottom. Set 7 at your level.
Machine shoulder press, anchor set	1	6→7→8	2-0-1-0	3:00	Two ramp sets. Level 2: failure plus rest-pause. Level 1: one in reserve.
Incline machine press, bridge	2	10→11→12	3-0-1-0	2:00	The chest's second day. Two in reserve.
Leaning cable lateral raise, superset	3	12→13→14 each side	2-0-1-1	none, straight into the next row	Hold the tower, lean away, cable from behind the body.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Reverse cable fly, superset	3	12→13→14	2-0-1-1	60 s after the round	Same tower. Arms long, pull wide, stop at the line of the torso. Past that point the shoulder blades squeeze and the traps take the work.

Substitutions: no chest-supported row machine, use a dumbbell row with the chest on an incline bench. No pulldown, use pull-ups, assisted if needed. No overhead cable for the pullover, use a dumbbell pullover. No machine shoulder press, use a seated Smith press. No incline machine, use an incline dumbbell press. No cable for the delt superset, use seated dumbbell lateral raises and a reverse pec deck stopped at the same point.

Day 4: Lower B

Focus: hamstrings and glutes. Quads, bridge sets. Abs superset to close.

EXERCISE	SETS	REPS	TEMPO	REST	NOTES
Romanian deadlift, anchor set	1	6→7→8	3-0-1-0	3:00	Three ramp sets. No rest-pause at either level. A hinge gets no second attempt when the back is tired. Level 2: to form failure, the rep where the back wants to round. Level 1: one in reserve.
Hip thrust, bridge	2	8→9→10	2-0-1-1	2:00	Chin down, ribs down, full lockout.
Seated leg curl, finisher	7	10→11→12	2-0-1-1	30–45 s	Same load all seven. Set 7 at your level.
Leg press, bridge	2	10→11→12	3-0-1-0	2:00	Two in reserve.
Leg extension, bridge	2	12→13→14	2-0-1-1	90 s	Two in reserve.
Cable crunch, superset	3	15→16→17	2-0-1-1	none, straight into the next row	Full range. Control the return.
Hanging leg raise, superset	3	10→11→12	2-0-1-0	60 s after the round	No swing. Control the descent.

Substitutions: not confident in the hinge yet, use a Smith machine Romanian deadlift, or run the hip thrust as the anchor on a Smith machine or glute machine and the Romanian deadlift as a bridge with three in reserve. No seated leg curl, use a lying leg curl for the finisher. No hip thrust setup, use a glute machine or a barbell glute bridge on the floor. No leg press, use a hack squat or a heavy goblet squat. No cable crunch, use a weighted crunch holding a plate. No hanging bar, use lying leg raises.

The week

DAY	SESSION	PRIORITY MUSCLE, FULL TREATMENT	BRIDGE SETS	SUPERSET TO CLOSE
Monday	Upper A	Chest	Back, side delts	Biceps, triceps

DAY	SESSION	PRIORITY MUSCLE, FULL TREATMENT	BRIDGE SETS	SUPERSET TO CLOSE
Tuesday	Lower A	Quads	Hamstrings	Abs
Wednesday	Off	None	None	Walk.
Thursday	Upper B	Back, plus a shoulder anchor	Chest	Side and rear delts
Friday	Lower B	Hamstrings and glutes	Quads	Abs
Saturday	Off	None	None	Walk.
Sunday	Off	None	None	Walk, stretch, mobility.

The rolling alternative: any four days work if two rules hold. Never more than two sessions in a row, and the order stays Upper A, Lower A, Upper B, Lower B. Monday, Tuesday, Thursday, Saturday works. So does Tuesday, Wednesday, Friday, Saturday. A missed day is slotted in on the next free day, never doubled.

The back anchor on Upper B is a chest-supported row on purpose. Lower B can fall on the next day, and a Romanian deadlift the day after a bent-over row puts two hard days in a row on the lower back. The chest pad takes the lower back out of the row.

Choosing your finishers

By default the four finishers go to chest, quads, back, and hamstrings and glutes. Those are the biggest muscles and they change how a body looks the most. If one part matters more to you, you may make one swap. Choose it before week 1 and keep it all eight weeks, so the record stays comparable.

YOU WANT MORE	THE SWAP	WHAT IT COSTS
Side delts	Day 1: the cable fly finisher becomes a dumbbell lateral raise finisher, 7 sets of 12→13→14. Cut out the very bottom, where a dumbbell puts no load on the delt.	The cable fly drops to two bridge sets of 12→13→14.
Biceps	Day 3: the pullover finisher becomes a behind-the-body cable curl finisher, 7 sets of 10→11→12.	The pullover drops to two bridge sets.
Triceps	Day 3: the pullover finisher becomes an overhead cable extension finisher, 7 sets of 12→13→14.	The pullover drops to two bridge sets.
Glutes	Day 2: the leg extension finisher becomes a machine hip abduction finisher, 7 sets of 15→16→17, torso leaned forward.	The leg extension drops to two bridge sets.

One swap, never two. Two finishers in one session is how a 55-minute session becomes 75 and how the anchor set the next time gets weaker.

Progression and troubleshooting

Adding load. Load changes once per block, at the start of week 5, and only on movements that hit the top of the ladder in week 3 at the written reps in reserve. 5 to 10 lb on big lifts, 2.5 to 5 lb on small ones. Mid-block the load holds and the reps climb. If an anchor set gets two or more reps past the bottom of its range in week 1, the load was wrong, not the plan. Go up next session and restart that movement's ladder.

A stalled lift. A lift stalls when the reps do not climb at the same load two weeks running. Hold the load. Add reps where you can, even one on one set. If it is still stalled after two weeks, drop the load 10 percent, run the ladder

from the bottom, and climb back. You will pass the old number on the way up. Grinding at the old load is how a stall becomes a month.

A missed session. Slot it in on the next free day and push the rest of the week along by one. Never double up. Two missed sessions in the same week means the plan is too big for that week. Run Plan B from the compliance page for the rest of the week and start the next week on schedule. The log tells you where you were.

Poor sleep. A night under six hours caps that day. The anchor set runs at the bridge load with two in reserve, no set to failure. The finisher runs as seven sets at two in reserve. A week of it is a deload trigger.

Losing weight fast. If the seven-day average drops more than one percent of bodyweight a week, run Level 1 until it slows. Failure work on a large deficit is how you lose muscle while trying to keep it.

Failing safely. An anchor set to failure is safe when the setup is right. Safety stops set before the set. A Smith machine with the hooks in reach. Failure on the Romanian deadlift is form failure, the rep where the back wants to round. If you cannot set a movement up safely, take the machine version from the substitutions to failure instead.

When to stop. Muscle fatigue is dull, spread out, and goes away with rest. Pain that is sharp, in a joint, on one side, or that changes how you move is not fatigue. Stop and see a professional. This plan is not medical advice.

Cardio and walking

Walk most days, 20 to 40 minutes, at a pace you could hold a conversation at. Walking is the fat-loss tool that costs the least recovery, and on this plan it is the cardio. The three days off are the best days for a longer walk.

Hard cardio is optional. If you want it, up to two short sessions a week, on a day off or after lifting, never before. Keep one day a week with nothing hard at all. Hard conditioning on top of four lifting days comes out of the legs first, and the leg anchors are where you will feel it.

The compliance page

Plan A, the full week

- All four sessions done, in order.
- All four sessions logged, reps in reserve included.
- Protein target hit every day, 1 g per lb of bodyweight as the default line.
- Weekly weigh-in average recorded.
- Walks done.

Plan B, the bare minimum

When the week blows up, Plan B is a full week. Two sessions: one upper, one lower. The upper session is the ramp sets and anchor set for the incline Smith press, the chest-supported row and the machine shoulder press, then two bridge sets of the pulldown. The lower session is the ramp sets and anchor set for the hack squat and the Romanian deadlift, then two bridge sets of the seated leg curl. No finishers, no supersets. One hard set per muscle keeps the stimulus alive and each session takes 30 to 40 minutes. Protein still hit. Sessions still logged. A Plan B week counts as a week done.

Three questions, every night

- Did I train today, or was it a planned rest day?
- Did I hit protein?
- Did I log it?

Yes or no. Nothing else.

The gate

Eighty percent on the three questions over four weeks means the plan is working. Change nothing before week four.

Week 1 checklist

- Bodyweight Monday morning, fasted, after the bathroom. Log it.
- Photos front, side, back, same light, same place.
- Pick your level and write it at the top of the log. Pick your finisher swap, or none.
- Read the whole of week 1 before day 1. Every table, every note.
- Put the four session days in a calendar now, with the time.
- Pick the Plan B days now, before you need them. One upper, one lower.

Discipline without integration is just a faster way to run in the wrong direction.

Stephen Dugger · stephendugger.com · steve@stephendugger.com

Written by Stephen Dugger with help from Claude, an AI model. Every rule in this plan is his.